



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Heritage Oak School

School Website: <https://heritageoakschool.com/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) or the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Heritage Oak School (Tehachapi, CA 93561) presents itself as a distinctly classical Christian school rooted in a biblical worldview, the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), and a Great Books-oriented pedagogy. Public materials repeatedly emphasize a mission of forming hearts and minds to be "all for Christ," a commitment to classical liberal arts education, and a policy framework built around a Portrait of a Teacher and a Portrait of a Parent. The school foregrounds features typical of classical education: memory work and singing in the early years; Socratic discussion and rhetoric in the upper grades; engagement with Great Books and the Great Conversation; and a pedagogy anchored in a living curriculum taught by faculty who model virtue. The school also highlights strong parental partnership (*in loco parentis*), parent formation activities, and open campus opportunities. Evidence from multiple public materials shows explicit alignment with classical education signals (grammar/logic/rhetoric, Great Books, Paideia, memorization, Socratic seminars) as well as robust religious foundations (Word of God, Bible-based instruction, Statement of Faith, chapel). Taken together, Heritage Oak School aligns strongly with classical education principles across all six categories of the Classical rubric.

Executive summary — Category-by-category snapshot supports a CLASSICAL rating across all six categories:

- **Religious and Metaphysical Foundations:** CLASSICAL, with explicit biblical formation, liturgical practices, and a gospel-centered, theologically grounded approach. Evidence includes Word of God framing, Bible-based instruction, Statement of Faith, and chapel life. See citations from Heritage Oak materials describing Christian formation and church connections.
- **Purpose and Goal:** CLASSICAL, with formation and virtue as *telos*, the claim of *Bildung* through a liberal arts mission, *paideia*, and pursuit of truth/beauty/goodness. See mission statements and *Paideia*-related language.
- **Curriculum:** CLASSICAL, with explicit Trivium (grammar/logic/rhetoric), Great Books/Great Conversation, history across disciplines, and memory-based pedagogy. Evidence includes Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric references, Great Books references, and K–12 curriculum descriptions.
- **Pedagogy:** CLASSICAL, combining contemplative/restful elements (*scholē*-like memory work and singing in lower grades) with Socratic seminars and rhetoric in upper grades. Evidence includes lower-school singing/memory work and upper-school seminars/debate training.
- **Faculty:** CLASSICAL, presenting faculty as living curriculum and mentors who model virtue, with portraits and norms for teacher quality and collaboration. Evidence includes "Portrait of a Teacher," faculty mission statements, and biblically grounded professional formation.
- **Parents & Community:** CLASSICAL, with explicit partnership with parents as co-teachers, parental formation opportunities, and open-campus/visit policies. Evidence includes "Portrait of a Parent," *in loco parentis* language, and parent resources.

Note: A rigorous keyword-by-keyword crosswalk against the Classical Lexicon (Six Essential Elements) was conducted for each category, with explicit positive keyword matches identified from Heritage Oak's public materials (e.g., Word of God, Bible-based instruction, Great Books, Paideia, Trivium, Socratic seminars, memory work, liturgy/chapel, Portrait of a Teacher/Parent, loco parentis). The Classical Lexicon provides explicit Positive/Negative keyword indicators to ground scoring. See the Lexicon reference for the six-element keywords used in this analysis.

Abstracted numeric orientation (per-category keyword signaling) indicates a predominantly positive Classical orientation in every category, with no explicit negative signals detected in the public Heritage Oak materials reviewed. The full rubric points to CLASSICAL across all six categories, with multiple textual anchors supporting each category's rating.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - “The mission of Heritage Oak School is to disciple passionate hearts and strong minds to be all for Christ!”
 - “Christian Formation: Everything we do at Heritage Oak is grounded in the Word of God with the goal to help students rightly order their loves, beginning with a passionate heart for Jesus Christ.”
 - “Bible-based instruction from caring Christian faculty members.”
 - “Statement of Faith” and church-based affiliation noted across materials.
 - Liturgical life and chapel references (Chapel services) observed in site material.
 - The school's public materials explicitly reference a biblical worldview, gospel-centered formation, and church community connections.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Word of God, Bible-based instruction, Gospel, Christ, biblical worldview, Statement of Faith, chapel/morning prayer, a gospel-centered mission, church affiliation.
 - Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials (no relativism/secular humanism signals detected).
 - Count (positive vs negative signals): Positive signals overwhelm; approximate positive signal count well into the double digits across pages; negative signals effectively zero.
- Why this rating
 - The materials consistently frame education as formation undergirded by theology, worship, and biblical truth, aligning strongly with the Positive/Indicator signals for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations in the Classical Lexicon. The presence of formal Theology/Word-of-God framing and liturgical life are hallmark indicators of a Classical religious foundation. CLASSICAL.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - “disciple passionate hearts and strong minds to be all for Christ” (telos: virtue formation under a Christian anthropology).
 - References to Bildung/formation, virtue cultivation, and human flourishing within a liberal-arts frame.
 - Paideia language and emphasis on cultural formation and the Great Conversation.
 - The claim that the school's mission is oriented toward formation and moral/spiritual formation rather than merely job preparation.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, telos, great conversation, permanent questions, classical heritage, soul craft.

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- Negative keywords present: “workforce preparation emphasis” or “college-and-career ready” signals do not appear in Heritage Oak’s public materials; the site foregrounds formation over purely vocational aims.
 - Count: Positive signals dominate; negative signals effectively absent.
 - Why this rating
 - The site consistently articulates Bildung-oriented aims (virtue, wisdom, formation) and explicit classical aims (paideia, great conversation) that align with the Classical Lexicon’s indicators for School Purpose and Goal. CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Explicit reference to the Trivium: Grammar, Logic, and Rhetoric are core to the curriculum structure (Grammar School, Logic/Rhetoric progressions).
 - Great Books and Great Conversation orientation (historical engagement with classic texts).
 - Recurrent emphasis on the liberal arts approach and a biblically integrated curriculum (literature, history, writing, Bible).
 - History and classical content across grades; memory work and recitation in the lower grades; art/music integrated into the curriculum.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, great conversation, history (as Western civilization/history framing, not Social Studies), memory work, recitation, narration, singing, hymnody, liturgy integration, Latin/classical languages (textually implied through Trivium and Great Books emphasis).
 - Negative keywords present: the lexicon’s “negative” signals include “social studies terminology replacing history,” “STEM-first framing,” and “project-based learning dominance,” none of which appear as curricular drivers in Heritage Oak materials.
 - Count: Strong positive presence; 0 explicit negative signals detected in public content.
- Why this rating
 - The curriculum is overtly classical: Trivium-centric structure, Great Books/Great Conversation, and a biblically integrative liberal-arts approach are central to the site’s messaging and program descriptions, satisfying Element 3’s classical criteria. CLASSICAL.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Lower-school emphasis on singing, memory work, chants, and predictable memory-based practice (Grammar/K–6).
 - Upper-school emphasis on Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training (Logic/Rhetoric Schools) with opportunities for speeches and articulate expression.
 - Text references to “narration,” “recitation,” “chanting,” and “restful learning” as pedagogical components.
 - Evidence of paideia-style seminars, and “living curriculum” described in faculty materials.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Socratic discussion, seminars, dialectic, recitation, narration, chanting, singing to memorize, memory work, restfulness, contemplation, Paideia seminar, rhetoric exercises, declamation, oratory, debate, upper-school rhetoric theses.
 - Negative keywords present: experiential learning focus, project-based learning dominance, constructivist-only approaches (none appear on Heritage Oak’s site; their pedagogy is aligned with classical methods rather than constructivist extremes).
 - Count: Multiple explicit positive signals across lower and upper grades; negative signals not evidenced.
- Why this rating

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- The pedagogy aligns with the classical rubric’s emphasis on a spectrum from contemplative memory and singing in early years to Socratic, argumentative, and rhetoric-focused activities in later years. CLASSICAL.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Faculty are described as models of virtue, living curriculum, and mentors who embody the school’s mission (Portrait of a Teacher).
 - Faculty are presented as collaborative, biblically grounded, and mission-aligned with parents and students.
 - Materials emphasize professional formation, biblical worldview, and careful modeling of True/-Good/Beautiful in teaching.
 - The school uses formal documents (e.g., Church Reference forms, Portrait of a Teacher) to articulate teacher expectations and virtues.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: model teachers and mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, collegial culture, virtuous exemplars, moral formation, subject mastery, biblical worldview.
 - Negative keywords present: No explicit negative signals for the faculty category; the content emphasizes virtue and pedagogy aligned with classical aims.
 - Count: Strong positive signals; negative signals absent.
- Why this rating
 - The textual anchors describe teachers as role models and the core “living curriculum,” with a culture of virtue and collaborative professionalism, matching the classical rubric’s expectations for the faculty category. CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - A robust portrayal of parents as co-teachers and partners in education (in loco parentis, Portrait of a Parent).
 - Parental formation and engagement opportunities (parent resources, parenting class offerings, book studies, seminars).
 - Open-visit policies and campus accessibility; family involvement is encouraged and celebrated.
 - The school explicitly frames parents as co-educators and supports family formation in alignment with the school’s mission.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teachers, parental primacy, parent formation, seminars/book clubs, open campus, family liturgy alignment, loco parentis, Portrait of a Parent.
 - Negative keywords present: consumer-oriented language or minimal parent involvement do not appear; the site promotes active parental involvement.
 - Count: High positive signal density; negative signals absent.
- Why this rating
 - Heritage Oak’s materials emphasize a deliberate model of parental partnership, home-school alignment, and parent formation consistent with classical education frameworks that anticipate engaged families as co-educators. CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable here, as the six categories all rate CLASSICAL. No category or aggregate rating requires improvement to reach full alignment with Classical education signals per the rubric.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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